Superhero

By Mark Harvey Levine

An apartment; morning. At lights up, Rachel is seen bound to a chair, a gag in her mouth.

RACHEL: *(Muffled from the gag.)* Help ... help! *(There is a loud thump, the sound of somebody running into the door.)* Oh, wait, it's locked. *(Rachel effortlessly gets out 0/ the chair, unlocks her front door, and returns to the chair, "re-tying" herself)* Try it again. *(She puts the gag back on her mouth.) (Nothing happens.) (Sighing.)* Help, help. *(Immediately, Leonard bursts through her door. He is a slight man dressed like a superhero. His costume is obviously, and rather pathetically, homemade.)*

LEONARD: *(His slogan')* I'm here to help!

RACHEL: Thank God you're here.

LEONARD: I picked up your cry for help. Luckily, I was in the hallway taking out my garbage at the time. What happened, citizen?

RACHEL: Ruffians!

LEONARD: *(He starts to untie her, not noticing how easy it is.)* Ruffians?

RACHEL: They tried to rob me. But they heard you and ran.

LEONARD: They won't get far. *(His exit line.)* Stay strong, citizen! *(He starts to leave.)*

RACHEL: Leonard! Don't go!-

LEONARD: I'm not Leonard! Leonard is my friend. He helps me in my exploits.

RACHEL: Oh, sorry, sorry. I forgot. But I have to call you something - you haven't picked out your name yet.

LEONARD: My name has to come from my powers. And I don't know what they are - yet. I know I can't fly. *(Obviously there's a story here.)*

RACHEL: You'll figure it out.

LEONARD: *(Preparing to leave again.)* Stay strong, citizen.

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INTRODUCTION

Actor: *Don't get me angry. You would not like me when I am angry!*
Actress: *With great power comes great responsibility.*
Actor: *My spider sense is tingling!*
Actress: *Is it a bird? Is it a plane? No! It's Superman!*
Actor: *These are sayings from some of the world's favourite superheroes. They are the Incredible Hulk, Spider-Man and the original superhero, Superman!*
Actress ***:****Superheroes use their special powers to rescue people in danger or difficult situations. They must have a strong desire to help.*
Actor: *Superheroes do not usually like to tell many people about their special powers. So, they must be good at keeping a secret. This may mean that they do not have many close friends. So superheroes must be prepared to be lonely at times.*
Actress: *But here's the most important component . . . . Have you been ignored, insulted,*
Actor: *Discarded all your life?*
Together: *Then you just may be a Superhero by Mark Harvey Levine.*

LEONARD: *(Preparing to leave again.)* Stay strong, citizen.

RACHEL: Wait! Help!

LEONARD: What's wrong?

RACHEL: Well, it's just ... urn ... *(Indicates pastry box nearby.)* I've got all these danishes, and I won't be able to eat' em all. Want one? *(She pulls out a chair for him.)*

LEONARD: That's not a-! You- It's- *(He's frustrated into speechlessness.)*

RACHEL: If you don't eat it, it'll go to waste! Isn't it a crime to waste food?!

LEONARD: Yes, but-

RACHEL: Well, here is a crime you can prevent! Have some breakfast. You want coffee?

LEONARD: I'm on duty!

RACHEL: Superheroes can't sit down and eat a meal?

LEONARD: At this very moment I'm locked in a terrible struggle with Claw Woman.

RACHEL: Claw Woman?!

LEONARD: ... You may know her as Esther Manning, in 316.

RACHEL: Oh yeah! Her. With all the cats.

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LEONARD: She's a Grasping Harpy of Evil. Our contest of wills has escalated. Only one of us will survive.

RACHEL: Well, you can't defeat her on an empty stomach. Have you eaten anything yet?

LEONARD: ... I had a bowl of frosted flakes.

RACHEL: You're running around on nothing but cereal?! Now that is a crime. Sit down. I've got apricot.

LEONARD: Apricot My favorite. Resistance . . . weakening . . . Getting . . . hungry Must . . . turn . . . away . . .

RACHEL: Want me to heat' em up?

LEONARD: No! What if evil strikes and I'm sitting here with a mouth full of tangy apricot filling? I have to go. Stay strong! *(He goes to leave again.)*

RACHEL: Oh wait, help! Sorry, sorry, there's one more thing. If you don't mind.

LEONARD: Now what?

RACHEL: Well ...

LEONARD: Your life had better be in danger.

RACHEL: Well ... urn, I can't get to that bulb up there.

LEONARD: You want me ... to change a lightbulb?!

RACHEL: I thought with your super-height, you could reach it. Sorry.

LEONARD: Rachel, you've got to stop calling me in, unless it's an actual emergency! I'm a superhero!

RACHEL: I know. I'm sorry.

LEONARD: What if sorneone's really in trouble, and I'm here ... fixing your disposal?!

RACHEL: Sorry, sorry.

LEONARD: ... How IS the disposal, by the way?

RACHEL: Oh, it's great! You did a fabulous job with -

LEONARD: All right then. 'Sides, you don't need a superhero, you need the super. Where IS Mr. Crazciek?

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RACHEL: He won't come up to this floor since you defeated him in battle.

LEONARD: Right. Now, Rachel. I'm going to change your lightbulb, as a favor, because you're a nice person. *(He gets a chair and stands on it.)* But then you must never call me again, unless it's an actual life-or-death emergency. Not to change a lightbulb, not to set your VCR, not to buy you the paper. This is it.

RACHEL: *(Unreasonably worried about him on the chair.)* Oooo, careful ...

LEONARD: I don't run errands - I fight evil!

RACHEL: *(The old schoolyard trick, she grabs him and shakes bim.)* Saved your life! *(She laughs a little too giddily, stays hanging on.)*

LEONARD: Rachel ... you wanna let me go?

RACHEL: *(Reluctantly lets go of him, overly nervous.)* OK! I'm sorry. Please be careful. Please.

LEONARD: This is nothing! I spent all yesterday battling Claw Woman and her Cat Minions. Get me a new bulb.

RACHEL: *(As she does so.)* How many cats DOES she have?!

LEONARD: I think she has all of them.

RACHEL: *(Finding the bulb, unreasonably scared for Leonard.)* Yeah, seriously ... Ooo! Careful! Careful!

LEONARD: *(She hands him the bulb.)* They keep getting on my balcony and attacking my plants. They killed my ficus. I must avenge his death. *(Like a comic book:)* The bulb! I- I can't reach it!

RACHEL: That's OK, that's OK, just get down, get down!

LEONARD: You think I accept defeat so easily? Ha! *(He stacks two or three chairs on top of one another. It looks incredibly precarious. He starts to climb up.)*

RACHEL: *(Completely panicked.)* NO! DON'T! *(She restrains him.)*

LEONARD: What? What's the matter with you?

RACHEL: You're going to get hurt! Don't!

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LEONARD: Rachel, please!

RACHEL: No! No! You're going to fall and break your neck and it'll be my fault! Please! Forget the light! Please!

LEONARD: All right, all right ... calm down! Sheesh!

RACHEL: I'm sorry. It's just - I'm afraid of heights.

LEONARD: You were on the ground.

RACHEL: I'm afraid of heights for other people.

LEONARD: You weren't in danger, Rachel.

RACHEL: I am in danger! We all are! Look at this! *(She grabs the neiospaper.)* Bus crashes, home-invasion murders, random shootings, breast cancer, bridge collapses, killer bees! Ewgh! *(She rips an article out of the paper.)* I am in danger! I'm in terrible danger, Leonard!

LEONARD: *(Angrily.)* I'm not Leonard! Leonard is, like you, afraid of everything! Leonard goes to work alone and comes home alone and sits alone in his apartment and eats his meals over the sink and watches TV until he falls asleep. But not me.

RACHEL: OK-

LEONARD: That's how I found out I was a superhero. I always WAS one, but I didn't know it! Nobody told me! They kept it hidden from me!

RACHEL: OK, OK, shh, shh, relax honey.

LEONARD: *(Getting very worked up.)* I should have known, though. It was there all the time. How come I always got the parking ticket, the broken shoelace? How come I always arrive JUST as they're flipping over the sign that says "closed"? Why do they imitate my voice at work when they think I'm not around? Why such a large conspiracy to destroy me? There can only be one reason! I'm dangerous to them!

RACHEL: *(Afraid.)* Yes, you are, honey, you are, you are.

LEONARD: Now, I don't know what my powers are, but I do know that I'm brave! Strong!

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Invincible!

RACHEL: That's very-

LEONARD: *(Coming at ber.)* I'm afraid of nothing!

RACHEL: *(Backing into a corner.)* I'm a little afraid of you, I'm afraid.

LEONARD: You're afraid of everything! Just like Leonard -

RACHEL: It's true, it's true! I'm a chicken! I'm afraid of bugs, and microwave ovens, and cancer and subways and Rod Stewart and nuclear war –

LEONARD: They did this to you, Rachel! Don't you see? It's just what happened to Leonard. When you were in school, were you the last person picked for the team?

RACHEL: Always.

LEONARD: When you stand at the deli, does the lady behind the counter stare into space like you're not even there?

RACHEL: Yes ...

LEONARD: Have you been ignored, insulted, discarded all your life?

RACHEL: Yes!

LEONARD: Rachel! You're a superhero!

RACHEL: *(Laughs nervously.)* Oh no no no.

LEONARD: You are, and you don't know it!

RACHEL: Oh, no. Please. Are you kidding me? I'm nobody.

LEONARD: That's what I thought. But you'll know when you put the uniform on. Try it.

RACHEL: Oh, no, no, that's all right, really -

LEONARD: I'm serious. *(As in a comic book.)* You have no idea the power you'll feel - pure energy coursing through your veins! *(Then, as himself)* It's really kinda cool!

RACHEL: No, thanks.

LEONARD: Come on.

RACHEL: ... Well, maybe just the cape. *(He removes his cape and puts it on her.)*

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LEONARD: There. How do you feel?

RACHEL: Like a lady in a cape.

LEONARD: You have to have the gloves, too. *(He removes his gloves, she puts them on. During this -*) They go with the cape.

RACHEL: And very smartly, too. *(He hands her the underwear.)* Um ...

LEONARD: I've only worn these on the outside.

RACHEL: S orry, I had to ask. *(She puts them over her slacks.)*

LEONARD: OK ... now ... the mask.

RACHEL: Is that OK?

LEONARD: I ... I guess so. I mean, if you want to get the whole effect ... *(Leonard removes his mask. Rachel smiles at him. Leonard looks expectantly, and she realizes what she's supposed to do.)*

RACHEL: My God! Leonard! It's you!

LEONARD: Yes ... It's me. I had to conceal my identity from you, for your own safety. But now well, there are no secrets between superheroes.

RACHEL: Oh, honey, I'm not a superhero.

LEONARD: Aren't you? Put on the mask. *(She does. She now has Leonard's costume on, and he is more or less normally dressed.)* You sure look like one. Try walking around. *(She shuffles around.)* No, no! You have to stride forward, with purpose! Fists clenched! Head high! Never turn back! You turn back, you trip over your cape. How do you feel?

RACHEL: Completely ridiculous. Leonard, I don't think I'm cut out to be a superhero . . .

LEONARD: Of course you are ... I can't be wrong about this. I'm never wrong about this.

RACHEL: Leonard, I'm just the lady who lives across the hall from you. If you want, you can come over and have breakfast sometime -

LEONARD: Fine then! Have it your way! And you can spend the rest of your life getting the parking tickets, the leaky faucets, and the dead plants! Because you're a

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loser! A failure! You SHOULD be picked last for the team! You should be laughed at and passed over and ignored and - *(Quite suddenly, Rachel slugs him in the jaw, surprising herself as well as Leonard. He goes down hard.)*

RACHEL: OhmiGod!

LEONARD: *(From the floor.)* ... Nicely done ...

RACHEL: OhmiGod! Are you OK?! I'm so sorry! I don't know why I did that! Are you OK?

LEONARD: *(In great pain.)* Sure ... No problem ... Don't forget, I'm a superhero. And so are you. Feels good, huh?

RACHEL: I've never hit anyone before!

LEONARD: Well you're ... doing swell, for a beginner.

RACHEL: I can't believe I -

LEONARD: It's the uniform. It's amazing what it does, isn't it?

RACHEL: Yeah, I guess so ...

LEONARD: Congratulations. Today, for the first time, you fought back against the forces of evil!

RACHEL: I did?

LEONARD: Sure. That nasty little voice inside you? I've got one, too. Of course, I also have Claw Woman in 316. *(She laughs.)*

RACHEL: Leonard, I think you've ... awakened my inner Wonder Woman ... *(She climbs up on the chair. She poses, superhero-ly)* Hey.

LEONARD: What?

RACHEL: Hey!

LEONARD: What?!

RACHEL: You saved my life ... (Lights fade.)

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